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Culture (OWC): [Tsonga \(FT06\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1895-1909

Coverage Date: 1895-1926

Place Coverage: South Africa

Section Title(S): C) The Tinamu.

In this first category is included the daughter of my wife's brother (Shaputa versus Mboza). With her the relations are perhaps even more free than with my wife's younger sisters. I call her *nsati*. The intimacy is so great that I can hold her breasts (tamele mabele). I can do so even in the presence of my wife, who is her paternal aunt. She will be pleased to see that I am disposed to avail myself of my right to marry her, because her niece will thus become her *nhlamps*a, she will *hlampsela rarana*, i. e. become a second wife by the side of her father's sister. But I dare not take such a liberty with the girl if her father is on the spot and sees me. I probably do not possess the oxen to pay for her, and the father looks chiefly to the oxen.

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As already pointed out, all the girls belonging to my *bakoñwana* are in the same position towards me. I can marry them all... if I am rich enough to "lobola" them. The grand-daughter of my wife's brother is a *namu*, a *nsati*. She will probably be a baby whilst I am a grown-up man. Never mind! If I meet her, a little girl on her mother's back, I go and take her in my arms, and say to her: "Good morning, my wife!" As regards my wife's cousins, those whose father is a brother of my wife's father and who bear the same family name as my wife, they are also *tinamu*, but here a distinction must be made. Should the father of one of these girls be younger than my wife's father, I can marry her; but should he be older I must not do so. Why is this? Because the girl, belonging to an elder branch of my wife's family, takes precedence of my wife; she is her "*hosi*", her chief. On the other hand my wife, being my first wife, is the mistress of the house; this cousin of hers ought therefore to obey her. But she is her chief! That would not be right. The natural family relations would be disturbed.. Such a union is not taboo (a *psi yili*) but it must be avoided.

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The *second category of tinamu* includes those women whom I might marry, not on account of the prior right of a group to the women of another group, but because I might *inherit them*. They are the wives of my elder brothers. If their husbands die, I am their legal heir. Relations with them are easy. We joke together, but there is more reserve towards these tinamu than towards those 248 of the first category. Sexual intercourse with them is a great taboo, and a man daring to commit such a sin would be likened to a wizard: he has killed his brother. This is the sin called matlulana (App. VI). My younger brother's wives are not tinamu; we call each other ñwingi. I do not inherit them except in extraordinary cases when the deceased has no brother younger than himself.

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